

Poiesis

A common muse, a first impression, and a notebook to keep what it stirs. Niko's notes, sorted into one place, with questions and some honest pushback at the end.

1 · WHERE IT COMES FROM

GS: the thing Poiesis wants to be for everyone

In high school you were part of **GS**: a group that sat around a poem, read it on the spot, and talked about their own experience of it. The conversation connected to each person's relationship with Christ, but in a broad sense of spirituality and understanding of God. The tone was close to Mary Oliver: attention to ordinary life as a way into the sacred.

What made GS work, as you describe it:

- **One shared text**, read together, in the moment.
- **First reactions**, not prepared essays.
- **Personal experience** as the way in, rather than analysis.
- **A larger frame** (God, the spiritual life) that gave the talk depth.

Poiesis is an attempt to give that experience to people who don't have a GS.

2 · THE PITCH

A common model, pursued together

IN YOUR WORDS

A common model of pursuit through positive mimesis of an unobtainable model: a common muse that inspires all of us.

Everyone looks toward the same muse. Because no one can own it or "win" it, imitation lifts people instead of setting them against each other (Girard's good mimesis). The one design lever you single out: **guiding questions on the first impression**, so people are inspired to say something true instead of typing filler.

A second framing you use: **Twitter is organized threads; Poiesis is organized dialogue**. The thread is anchored to a muse rather than to a person or a trend.

The five pillars, in their boldest form

- 1 Works are meant to inspire a gift of imagination. A muse is received as a gift and answered with one.
- 2 You should always be able to capture your thoughts, wherever you are in the app.
- 3 Conversations must always be visible, with the maximum incentive to contribute well.
- 4 Always creation over consumption. Always.
- 5 The mystery of the muse cannot be scared off by optimization, envy or possession.

Three dialogues around one muse

Your clearest statement of focus: everyone has a **common muse** they contribute to, and the goal is to help people hold a dialogue **with the muse, with others, and with themselves**. Each part of the app serves one of those three.

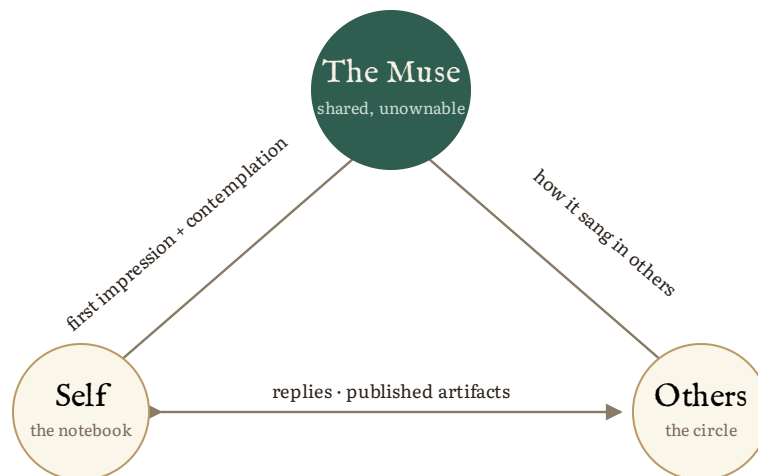


FIGURE 1 • EVERY FEATURE SHOULD STRENGTHEN ONE OF THESE THREE LINES

What gets curated, and how

A muse can be art, poetry, a passage, a quote, or a question.

Synthesis as genius

Muses shouldn't arrive at random. You want them to **come in themes**, to **contrast with each other**, and to **span different mediums**, so that putting them side by side draws out distinctions a single work can't. The curation itself becomes an argument.

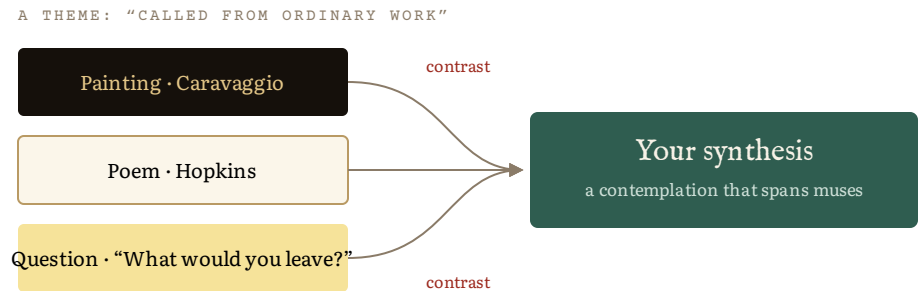


FIGURE 2 • THREE MEDIUMS ON ONE THEME; THE INSIGHT LIVES BETWEEN THEM

- One first impression and one contemplation per muse.
- Open idea: allow **one comment across several muses**, to reward synthesis.
- Open idea: when you look at a muse, see **every work ever published** in response to it.

Why people write, and write well

INCENTIVE	WHAT IT DOES
BeReal-style gate	You leave your first impression before you can read anyone else's, so the thought is yours first.
Guiding questions	Every first impression starts from a prompt, so people are inspired rather than filling a box.
Stickers	Scarce, daily, collectible; worn on your profile and on your published pages.
Proper meditation	The muse is framed to be sat with before answering, not scrolled past.
Molding the muse	Your creative imagination adds to the muse; your answer becomes part of what the next person meets.

And a record-keeping principle: **dialogues are saved**, and you can refresh to see every chat.

Organizing thought, from seed to publication

Alongside the dialogue, a tool to **organize your thoughts and keep curated inspiration**. Its artifacts move through stages:

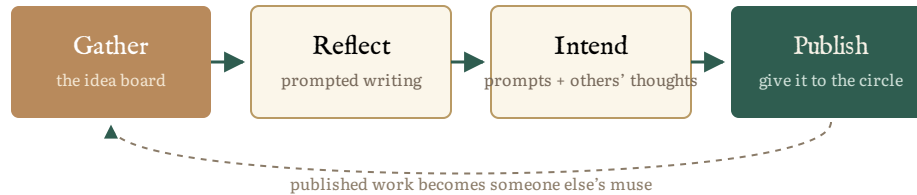


FIGURE 3 • NOTEBOOK ARTIFACTS, FROM SEED TO GIFT

- **Stickers on the page.** Writers place the stickers of the muses they drew on, like citations.
- **Reference rating.** Readers judge whether a muse was a significant reference or just decoration. (See pushback 2.)
- **Offline mode.** Download the day's muse and write, with no connection.

An interactive newsletter with patrons

Funding

Poiesis is an **interactive newsletter**. Fund it the way Substack writers are funded: **patrons and paid subscriptions**.

Marketing

Invite people to **respond to muses on TikTok and Instagram**, and **publish notebook artifacts to Substack** so the work travels.

What the prototype already shows: the daily letter (PDF), five muses a day, the first-impression gate, one later thought, daily stickers, three-day conversations that close to a “best of”, and a notebook with journal, scrapbook, idea boards, trash and rule of life.

Where the ideas pull against each other

I • “Always visible” vs. “the muse is fleeting”

Pillar 3 and “save all dialogues” say conversations stay forever. Last round you asked for discussions to vanish after three days because the muse is fleeting. Both can't be the headline.

TRY: Conversations close to new posts after three days but remain readable forever, best-of first, full archive one tap away. Fleeting to join, permanent to read.

2 · Rating references is a scoreboard

Letting the audience rate whether your muse sticker was “significant” is public judgment of each other’s work. That is rivalry mimesis, the thing pillar 5 and the whole Girard premise are built against.

TRY: Make it a private signal to the author (“this reference landed for me”), or let curators mark exemplary uses. Never show a number.

3 · Stickers are an optimization, and pillar 5 forbids optimization

Scarcity and collecting are exactly the dopamine mechanics that produce the filler you’re trying to prevent: people will type a quick line to unlock a sticker.

TRY: Keep stickers small and private-ish (no counts, no leaderboards), and think about tying them to the contemplation rather than the first impression, so the reward follows depth, not speed.

4 · GS worked because it was small, live and together

A circle in a room, one text, one hour. An app with thousands of strangers loses that. “Everyone has a common muse” is good; “everyone talks to everyone” is not.

TRY: Circles of 8–15 people reading the same muse, like a GS group, with the wider archive readable but secondary.

5 · Scope: this is four products

A newsletter, a social network, a notebook app, and a curated publishing platform, plus offline mode and Substack export. Each is a company on its own.

TRY: MVP = the letter + first impression + small circles. Prove people come back and write well. The notebook comes second.

6 · Copyright will shape the muses

Mary Oliver, most 20th-century poets and many modern translations are under copyright. You can’t reprint them in a paid newsletter without permission.

TRY: Lean on the public domain (Keats, Hopkins, Dickinson, the King James Bible, paintings), use short excerpts with commentary, and license a few living voices as the business grows.

7 · TikTok and Instagram run on the opposite values

Marketing there is fine as a door, but responses built for those feeds are performances for an audience, which undercuts the “first impression is yours” idea.

TRY: Post the muse and a question, not people’s responses; let the answering happen inside Poiesis.

8 · The faith question is still open

GS was explicitly about relationship with Christ; the prototype is implicit and ecumenical. Both are valid, but they attract different people and a different curator voice.

TRY: Decide who the first 100 users are. That answer settles the tone.

10 · OPEN QUESTIONS

For you to answer next

- 1 Who are the first 100 people? *Your GS friends, UD students, Christians broadly, writers, anyone curious?*
- 2 Is Poiesis a newsletter **on** Substack, or a product that competes with it?
- 3 After three days: does a conversation disappear, close but stay readable, or stay open forever?
- 4 What earns a sticker: the first impression, the contemplation, or publishing something?
- 5 How many muses a day? GS had one text; the prototype has five. Is one deeper than five?
- 6 Who curates? You alone at first, a small group, or eventually guest curators per theme?
- 7 What does “contemplation” mean in the product: the one later thought, or a longer notebook piece that can span several muses?
- 8 Should a live GS-style mode exist, where a circle reads and answers together at a set hour?
- 9 Is reference rating essential, or would private “this landed” signals do the job?
- 10 What do patrons actually pay for: supporting the letter, joining circles, or notebook features?

Answer these and the next version of the app nearly designs itself.